

CAMBRIDGE HARKENER

CELEBRATING THE HERITAGE OF CAMBRIDGE, VERMONT

Vol. XX, No. 2

November 2025

Current Officers & Directors

President:	Joel Page	Directors::	Jennifer Bartlau, Diancy Boyden,
Vice President:	Rick Fletcher		Richard Gagne, Georgeana Little,
Secretary:	Richard Gagne		Peter Opstrup, Shirley Opstrup, Kimberly
Treasurer:	Georgeana Little		Parsons

Honorary Board Members: Diancy Boyden, June Dodge, Barb Juell, Lynn Austin

President's Review of 2025 CHS Activities

Joel Page, CHS President

It has been another busy year for the Cambridge Historical Society. We presented seven programs, published "The Cambridge Harkener", collaborated with numerous organizations, and held a very well attended open house on July 4.

The seven programs covered a wide range of topics. Most were recorded and can be viewed on YouTube through a link with the CHS Facebook page, or by links on our website (www.cambridgehistoricalsociety.org).

The programs were:

March: Gert Gonyo Interview - *Spending Summers in Cambridge in the 1940s and 1950s*

April: Becky Rupp - *A History of Trees*

May: Jen Bartlau - *From Soldiers to Settlers, Connecting Cambridge to the Revolution*

June: Kevin Graffagnino - *A History of Ira Allen*

July: Amanda Gustin - *Vermont on the Silver Screen, 100 Years of Vermont in Film*

September: Zeke Zucker & Laird McDowell - *History of the Cambridge Fun Run*

October: *A conversation with Eric Tobin* at the Bryan Gallery

Our newsletter "The Cambridge Harkener" continues to be published and sent to you, thanks mostly to the talents and efforts of Geana Little. This year the Harkener once again features the Wilcox family history of Robert Murray Burns, as well as "An Early History of Cambridge", by Ida Morgan Anderson. Look to the Harkener as well, for updates about CHS activities.

The Annual Meeting in November includes election of officers and directors. The big news this year is that Diancy Boyden is retiring as a Director after more than 20 years of dedicated service. Thank you Diancy for all you have done for CHS over the many years! Big shoes to fill..

The Collections Committee continues to meet regularly and plug away at digitizing and organizing items in our collection. Some day we hope you will be able to electronically access most of our collected items, especially our photographs. Peter Opstrup, Jim Lonergan, and Hugh List are the brains behind this operation, thank you gents!

The Finance Committee and the Board of Directors regularly review our budget and finances. We operate on a very frugal budget. Fortunately, we have an investment account that, depending on the market, provides a modest income stream. Presently, our income from

Early History of Cambridge

by Ida Morgan Anderson

Beginning in 1935, Ida Morgan Anderson began serializing a column on the History of Cambridge in the *Cambridge Town Crier*. Many of our readers may remember the series of 27 Installments. The Harkener continues publishing the installments for a new audience on the assumption that the copyright (if it ever existed) has long since expired. We hope you will enjoy these "blasts from the past."

Installment Twenty-four

The previous evening word came over the telephone that a part of the Morrisville dam had gone out, and there would be high water in Cambridge in a few hours. Three-fourths of the people paid no attention to the warning. High water had never touched them and it wouldn't this time. There was no danger. The warning spread, and A.H. Hooper of Fletcher, knowing that the village would not have boats enough for such an emergency, sent a truck to Metcalf Pond and ran two row-boats down here in record time. These boats were manned by Donald Hooper, Floyd Tinker, Perley Hooper, and James Coolum and with Harry King and other local boys did heroic work. The water was full of debris, logs and boards, and the current was strong. As Henry Krebsner and his family crawled through the chamber window and slid over the veranda roof into the boat, they could feel the house trembling beneath them, and heard the crash of glass as the water hurled the logs and debris against the windows.

They were quickly landed at the foot of the hill, where Joe Roberts, waiting with his car, raced up and down, carrying refugees up to Merrill Clark's and safety, as fast as they landed.

Among them was Mrs. Leon Wood and her week-old daughter. She was moved five times. First, to the chamber of their home. Then to Mr. LaPoint's, then to Mr. Bixby's, and as the water rose so fast they dared not

stay, she was put through the chamber window into a boat, and at the foot of the hill Joe Roberts' car took her up to Merrill Clark's. Next day she was taken to Henry Patterson's at North Cambridge. Neither mother nor child were any worse for their exciting experience.



Eighteen or nineteen of the Riverside folks went up the hill and spent the night with friends on nearby farms. That verse, "I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills from whence cometh my help." will always hold a meaning for them.

The remainder of the Riverside families made a roundabout trip through the woods and reached Otis Sherman's, where they were fed and lodged for two nights. Mr. and Mrs. Sherman also had their neighbors from the Warner farm and Mrs. John Learned among their guests. Mr. And Mrs. Cheeseman, who lived in the little red house on Mr. Learned's farm were marooned in the attic until Saturday, with only a small can of raspberries (sic) in the line of food. Not a very satisfying diet.

The electric light service had not yet been

memberships, donations and book sales does not cover expenses, so we are relying on some of the investment income to make up the difference.

Our membership numbers are fairly stable, though we are losing more members to the passage of years than we are gaining new members. We presently have about 90 members, and the Board continues to explore ways of attracting more young members.

CHS continues to collaborate with other groups to enhance our community we:

- Collaborated with the Bryan Gallery to present a public conversation with landscape painter Eric Tobin. This was the third of three conversations with people closely involved with the Bryan Gallery and the history of local landscape painting. (Alden Bryan Jr. and Jane Shaw were interviewed last year). The conversations were recorded by CHS Director Richard Gagne using our equipment. (Richard has recorded and edited most of our productions);
- Collaborated with a Civil War group dedicating a roadside historical marker commemorating the Grand Army of the Republic (GAR), which was very active in Cambridge;
- Partnered with Cambridge Elementary School to present local history to students.
- Participated in the Village of Cambridge History Walk;
- Participated in a Milton Historical Society statewide event;
- Provided information to a writer who is publishing a book about the Burlington-Lamoille Railroad;
- Hosted a Krusch Preserve presentation about a possible land purchase;
- Participated in an event with the Vermont Covered Bridge Society at the Poland Bridge in Cambridge Junction;
- Researched and provided information to many individuals who contacted CHS with questions relating to the history of Cambridge.

On the Fourth of July we held an Open House that was very well attended. The historic Masonic Lodge on the second floor was open, and Peter Opstrup was kept busy giving tours and answering questions. On the first floor, Jen Bartlau was busy guiding visitors through the “Soldiers to Settlers, Connecting Cambridge to the Revolutionary War” exhibit she has assembled.

I am very proud of what CHS has accomplished during 2025, and I continue to be optimistic about our future. Our programs, books, videos, projects, and collaborations make important contributions to our community. My thanks to the volunteers, Board, Officers, and members who have worked so hard to accomplish so much.

cut off, and the bright lights streaming from the windows of the houses on Mansfield Avenue, lent an unearthly look to the terrifying scene. The roar of the raging waters, the pitiful cries of helpless, frightened drowning cows, hogs and poultry the crash of buildings as they were torn from their foundation or logs were hurled against them, the shouts of the workers and the screams of the feeble as they were lowered from the windows into the boats, were appalling. Speaking of it afterwards, one woman said, "It rang in my ears for days."

But these young men, Melbourne LaPoint, Ed Howard, Harry King, Leo Horner, K. Perry, the boys from Fletcher and others, unused to rougher water than a pond or spring freshet, rose to the occasion and worked like veterans. There was not one accident. No one was injured, and the sick taken from their beds and put through the window were no worse from the danger and excitement. It was hard, dangerous work requiring skill and courage of a high order, but they went about it in the calm matter-of-fact way in which they would tackle any other hard job. We salute the quiet heroes of every day life. And in our minds we decorate you with the cross of the "D.S.O." Distinguished Service Order.

There is no longer any occasion to doubt the story of the ant who told Noah to "Go long with this old ark. He didn't believe it would be much of a shower, anyway." The unbelief with which so many of Main Street and Mansfield Avenue received the news of the approaching flood, would be funny if it were not as pathetic and fraught with so much loss that might have been avoided.

W. H. Lang voiced the opinion of many, when a neighbor ran in at nine o'clock to warn him to seek safety. "Why, see here," he said, "I've lived here for fifty years and the river has never done any great damage here yet. I won't tonight. High water won't touch this street." and he went to bed with a mind perfectly at rest. Mrs. Lang, not so fully satisfied, got up once or twice and looked around to see if there was any truth in the rumor. When she stepped in water that had begun creeping across the floor, she believed there was. Then they got busy. The rug was rolled up and laid on the couch where it could keep dry. Some clothing and books were thrown on the bed where they would be safe, and the flour barrel set on the range. By that time the water was so deep on the floor that a boat was hailed and they were taken to the home of Mrs. M.M. Reynolds. They were among the first to leave home, and from the front and side verandas they watched the whole thrilling scene. Later, it was a shock to find that the water rose to a depth of five feet in their cozy home and their precautions all went for naught.

It surrounded the home of E. J. Gates. It even entered the stable of Willey Brothers' barn at the upper end of the village near the rail road track and their cattle had to be driven to the high ground across the road.

Twenty people were fed and lodged at H. N. Grays. The Chayer sisters had C.A. Corse's family. Lloyd Ring's family stayed at George Perrys; Edwin Howard's family at Carl Sweets; Mrs. H.W. Burns and children at Will Burns. A number of people took refuge with Mr. and Mrs. W. H. Ridley at the hotel. The water drove them, to the second floor where they were without fire and very little food. They were realizing what it meant to be shipwrecked and castaways, when the first relief boat was rowed to the front door with food.

The story of the 1927 flood continues in subsequent installments of Ida Morgan Anderson's history and will continue here in our next issue of the Harkener.

Programs

We are putting together our programs for 2026.

April

Schoolhouses of Cambridge

May

Central Vermont's Burlington & Lamoille Railroad: Queen City to Cambridge Junction

June

The Revolutionary War Continues

August

History of the Cambridge Volunteer Fire Department

September

History of the Cambridge Greenway

November

Cambridge Historical Society Annual Meeting and Election of Officers

December

Christmas Party*

There will be at least one, as yet unscheduled and unidentified, oral history video.

We are still looking for programs for March, July, and October. If you have any ideas for programs or would like to present one yourself, please contact Georgeana Little (rgtle@stoweaccess.com).



**If you wish to attend this year's Christmas Party on December 10th, please bring a gift for the Yankee Swap for each person (no more than \$10) and a dish to share. All are welcome.*

Membership Application/Renewal

Please complete this form and mail to: Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464-0016
or email to: rgtle@stoweaccess.com

☐ New

☐ Renewal

Name _____

Address _____
Number Street Town State Zip

Phone _____ E-Mail _____

Membership Category

☐ Individual \$20.00

☐ Family \$30.00

☐ Business \$30.00

Please consider becoming a:

☐ Patron \$500.00

☐ Benefactor \$1,000.00+

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

If you have suggestions about program topics or have some great ideas for fundraisers,
please let us know by listing your ideas below.

Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464



It's the end of another year. We did a lot this year, as you can read in Joel Page's recap of 2025. We hope we can continue to present programs in the future. To assure our future, please renew your membership. Notices will be going out soon. Beat the rush. Renew now, because this newsletter, however sporadically issued, is a perk of your membership.

THANK YOU.